CORRUPTING AFRICA

International Organizations and 'the Problem' of Corruption in Africa

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"...In any given society corruption is a changing phenomenon, some of its aspects and received morality are culturally specific and...affected by personal interest, cultural values and socio-economic status...Corruption needs to be treated contextually."[1]

"Corruption has become an African epidemic. It is impossible to overstate the poisoning of human relations and the paralyzing of initiative that the corruption on the African scale brings."[2]

INTRODUCTION

Until the 1990s, **corruption** was often thought to be a byproduct of development and corporate business. But since then, combating corruption has become an accepted **international norm**, and corruption and **underdevelopment** in Africa have been synonymous in the discourse of international organizations.

The main themes of the accepted discourse on corruption are that it is **immoral** and a severe **obstacle** to:

- **Governance and Democracy**
- **Modernization**
- **Human Rights**
- **Development**

This study uses a critical analysis to explore the discourse on corruption and development in Africa, and the implications for anti-corruption initiatives by analyzing the anti-corruption rhetoric and activities of two international organizations:

- The United Nations **(UN)**
- The Organization on Economic Cooperation and Development **(OECD)**

STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM and SIGNIFICANCE

- How is corruption **understood** as a "problem" located in Africa and one that is inextricably linked to **underdevelopment** there?
- How is this discourse demonstrated in the international anti-corruption activities of the **UN** and the **OECD**?
- How is the **dominant** discourse a manifestation of power? Are other contextual understandings of corruption ignored?

The now dominant discourse on corruption in Africa has serious **implications** for development policy and international anti-corruption activities. The anti-corruption and development agendas implemented in the global South are founded upon **presumed** understandings of corruption as a certain type of problem. However, it is important to recognize that there are various understandings of **corruption that vary with context**. Thus, other discourses of corruption need to be explored while the flaws of the accepted one critically analyzed.

- **FACT 1:** The African countries Namibia, Mauritius, South Africa and Botswana have a higher ranking on the 2009 Corruption Perceptions Index – **which means they have less corruption** – than Italy, Greece, Brazil, and Bulgaria.
- **FACT 2:** In 1999, **19%** of indebtedness in the developing world was due to credit provided by export credit agencies (ECAs) to corporations in poor countries. Most ECA contracts were secured by **bribing foreign officials. Thus, poor countries' debt includes the cost of bribery by these corporations.**

RESULTS

- Some **UN** and **OECD** initiatives target corruption at the civil society level, but most overwhelmingly represent the interests and perspectives of **international businesses** on the problem of corruption and on anti-corruption activities.
- While their anti-corruption efforts are framed as promoting human rights, good governance and accountability in Africa, both ***quietly*** acknowledge the role of rich countries and Western corporations on corruption in the developing world.
- The OECD and UN take it upon themselves to "save" the developing world from corrupting itself, although corruption is still a severe obstacle in some European countries, multinational corporations, and export credit agencies.

OECD	UN
1997 Anti-Bribery Convention First global instrument to fight bribery in international business. Was passed because the OECD realized bribery was causing its corporations to lose profits.	**2003 Convention against Corruption:** States that corruption is a problem for civil societies and international corporations. Combating it requires international cooperation, accountability.
Working Group on Bribery Regulatory body of the OECD. Provides recommendations on making international business transactions more accountable.	**'Your NO Counts Campaign'** Encourages civil society in the global South to reject bribery. Distributes ads and posters in different languages.
Panel on Countering Corruption in International Business and Development Activities Further criminalized bribery of foreign officials.	**UN Global Compact** Policy initiative for multinational corporations committed to "universally" accepted principles: human rights, labor, environment, and **anti-corruption.**
Recommendation on Tax Measures disallows tax deductibility of bribes of foreign officials. Encourages transparency in taxing.	**UN Development Program: Program of Accountability and Transparency** Encourages transparency in businesses and non-profit organizations
Good Governance Practices for the Protection of Human Rights: UN document with a section on combating corruption. Also, a section written by the **OECD** likening anti-corruption to promoting human rights. Discusses bribery in export credit agencies but still locates the problem of corruption in the developing world.	

DISCUSSION

The analysis of the **OECD** and **UN**'s discourse and anti-corruption efforts demonstrate that**:**

- The international anti-corruption movement is *primarily* framed, organized, and coordinated in the **global North**, while corruption is *primarily* viewed as a problem in poor countries.
- Corruption is understood to be a cause of **underdevelopment**, not a result. Thus, development policies for Africa typically include anti-corruption initiatives.
  - **Szeftel** argues this is misguided.
- It is **assumed** to be in the interest of governments, businesses, *and* civil society to combat corruption, regardless of social, political, economic, historical or cultural **context.**
  - For some in Africa, corruption is a necessary way of life, or a consequence of European colonialism; this is ignored.
- Despite their contributions to the problem, **multinational corporations** are seen as a solution, so much so that their perspectives on corruption are overwhelmingly represented in international anti-corruption initiatives.
  - **Szeftel** argues that international organizations have even attempted to replace the role of African governments in development policy. This "**governance agenda**" has actually *increased* corruption in parts of Africa.[4]

"*Put bluntly, corruption is a **cancer** that corrodes value, trust and public welfare. It destroys **competitive markets**, leading to unfinished roads, crumbling schools and crippled health systems. **Democracy** is weakened and millions of people are kept in **poverty**.*" Angel Gurria, OECD Secretary General



"What's a level playing field, Daddy?"

"***The OECD Anti-Bribery Convention** is not just about morals and ethics in clean business practices. It is about fair play and **leveling the playing field as well.**"* The OECD *Observer* Dec 2004

In conclusion, there are **contradictions** between the *discourse* on corruption and the actual problem itself; the dominant discourse is an extension of capitalist and Western **imperialism**. Other discourses on corruption are not given equal merit as the one propagated by international organizations and corporations . There needs to be a more honest, **nuanced**, wholesome and critical understanding of corruption to truly encompass an international anti-corruption movement that combats corruption appropriately.

[1]Harrison, Elizabeth. "Corruption: Discourses in Development." *Development in Practice* 17 (2007): 673. *Academic Search Premier*. 19 July 2010.
[2]Matthew Parris, *The Times*, 8 Aug 1997
[3]Szeftel, Morris. "Misunderstanding African Politics: Corruption and the Governance Agenda." *Review of African Political Economy* 25.76 (1998): 221-40.
[4]Ibid.

Picture taken from: <http://www.cartoonstock.com/newscartoons/directory/f/food_shortage.asp>